



The Lexmark C510

To tax the printers further, we printed a report with graphs, photos and text. Lexmark's C510 took the top slot, and was followed by Samsung's CLP-500. Lexmark was 50 per cent faster than the slowest printer, the HP LaserJet 2550L, in this particular test.

Our final test was the high-resolution photograph printout; this test would clearly crown the colour-printing king. We used a 37 MB file—large enough to test a printer's onboard memory performance.

As expected, Canon's LBP-2410 came out tops, taking only 41 seconds. The reason for this is simple—the Canon uses CAPT, which does data processing using the PC. The better the PC, the faster the printouts. Samsung's CLP-500 should be lauded for its equally good speed, and as was the case earlier, the Lexmark lost out due to its high spooling time. The Wipro took 60 seconds and was third-best.

When it comes to pages printed per minute (called PPM), the Lexmark C510, at 24 PPM, was the fastest of them all, followed by the Samsung CLP-500 at 15 PPM.

To conclude, Samsung's CLP-500 finished most of the tests fastest. Lexmark's C510, on the other hand, is much faster for small loads, but as the file size increases, the spooling times goes through the roof and slows down overall printing speed. The Canon and Wipro tied for third place.

The Printout Quality

While HP's LaserJet 2550L was never up there in terms of speed, it did produce some quality printouts to make up for lost ground.

In the combi-document, it reproduced the finer details perfectly, without distortion. Colour differentiation was perfect, and the range of seven colours in the combi-document was reproduced perfectly. Yellow text on a black

background tests the contrast level, and this was crystal clear. All this put the HP 2550L ahead of others in the quality comparison. Wipro's 4160 came in third, closely followed by the Lexmark C510.

The Samsung CLP-500, to some extent, sacrifices quality at the expense of speed. Graininess was visible where there was colour gradation, as with background colour. Colour shades were also lighter than normal. All this resulted in lower scores.

When we printed photographs, all the printers failed to match the results from an inkjet printer. The printed photographs completely lacked the vibrancy of colour. This is one area where inkjets score over colour laser printers. Amongst this bunch of lasers, HP produced the best photographs, but even these were not of acceptable quality.

Thus, although colour lasers have come of age, they fall behind when it comes to printing photographs. Your best bet for photographs



The Samsung CLP-500

would be photo-printers for professional requirements. However, most inkjets meant for desktop use, will do a good job at printing photographs for casual use.

Putting It Together

To summarise, the Samsung CLP-500 wins on features, followed closely by Lexmark's C510. On the performance scale, Lexmark's C510 is a hairs-breadth away from Samsung's CLP-500. However, it should be noted that as far as quality goes, Lexmark's C510 is much better than Samsung's CLP-500. However, HP's LaserJet 2550L is undoubtedly the best when it comes to quality of printout. Wipro and Canon are pretty much on par, both in terms of speed and quality of output.

Insert price into the equation, and the Wipro 4160 is the cheapest colour laser. However, Lexmark's C510 and the Samsung fight it out for the crown. Considering the Lexmark's good speeds and marginally better output quality, we award it the Best Buy Gold award.

The Samsung CLP-500, with its future-proof feature set and decent performance, is a good buy, and wins our Best Buy Silver award.

HP and Canon have some catching up to do with the competition. ☑

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